

Vladimir Žerjavić (2 August 1912 – 5 September 2001)^[1] was a [Croatian economist](#) and demographer who published a series of historical articles and books during the 1980s and 1990s on demographic losses in Yugoslavia during [World War II](#) and of Axis forces and civilians in the [Bleiburg repatriations](#) shortly after the capitulation of Germany. From 1964 to 1982, he worked as an adviser for industrial development in the [United Nations Economic Commission for Africa](#).^[2]

Early life

Žerjavić was born in [Križ, Zagreb County](#) and graduated at the Faculty of Economics at the [University of Zagreb](#).^[1] He was one of four siblings, having two sisters, Viktorija (1908–1993) and Darinka (1921–2009) and a brother, Slavko. After 1934 he worked in the private sector, and after 1945 in various institutions of [SFR Yugoslavia](#). Between 1958 and 1982 he worked abroad as an industrial consultant. In 1964 he joined the [United Nations Economic Commission for Africa](#) and later consulted the governments of various nations.^[1]

Žerjavić's calculations regarding [World War II in Yugoslavia](#)

In the 1980s Žerjavić conducted a research on demographic losses in Yugoslavia during World War II, at about the same time as [Bogoljub Kočović](#), a Serb statistician.^[3] Žerjavić's calculations of total victims in Yugoslavia are based on looking at pre- and post-war censuses. Žerjavić asserted that Yugoslavia lost a total 1,027,000 people in World War II.

His claims include 153,000 civilian victims in Croatia and 174,000 in Bosnia and Herzegovina, and of that, 85,000 people from Bosnia and Herzegovina and 48,000 from Croatia died in [concentration camps](#).^[7] As for the total casualties in [Jasenovac concentration camp](#), he estimated that 85,000 were killed, of which 45–52,000 were Serbs, 13,000 were Jews, 10,000 were Roma, 10,000 were Croats and 2,000 were Muslims.^[8]

With regard to [Serbs](#), Žerjavić's calculation ended with a total of 197,000 Serbian civilian victims within the borders of the [Independent State of Croatia](#): 50,000 at Jasenovac concentration camp, 25,000 of typhoid, 45,000 killed by the Germans, 15,000 killed by Italians, 34,000 civilians killed in battles between Ustaše, [Chetniks](#) and [Partisans](#), 28,000 killed in prisons, pits and other camps, etc. Another 125,000 Serbs inside the [Independent State of Croatia](#) were killed as combatants, raising the total to 322,000.^[5]

Regarding the [Yugoslav Partisan pursuit of Nazi collaborators](#), when soldiers and civilians associated with the NDH and other Axis forces were killed by the Yugoslav Partisans, Žerjavić estimated that around 45–55,000 Croats and Bosniaks, 8-10,000 Slovenes, and around 2,000 Serbs and Montenegrins were killed.^[9]

Žerjavić's opinions and statements

Žerjavić's investigations and statistical analyses, like others such as Kočović's examinations, aim to show that the original number of lives lost on all sides during [World War II](#) in Yugoslavia was considerably exaggerated, partly due to the [war reparations claims by the Yugoslav government shortly after the war](#).^[10]

An excerpt from Žerjavić's book *Manipulations with WW2 victims in Yugoslavia* reads:^[11]

One should also believe that the Serbs in Croatia, who have lived in these territories for more than four centuries, will realize that they are not endangered in a community with Croats. They especially should not be afraid that any form of genocide could occur, because they themselves know best that during the Second World War a large number of Croats stood at their defense, and that they, along

with Serbians, contributed to the National Liberation War, and even prevented a larger number of victims. It should be mentioned that the regular Croatian Army (Domobrani) also helped with their passive role and even by logistic support to the partisan units. [V]engeance for the crimes committed by the Ustaše was executed immediately after the war, with [the terrible massacres at Bleiburg and during the so-called Way of the Cross \(Death Marches\)](#), when many innocent opponents of the Communist regime were also killed. Therefore, enacting vengeance against the Croats, with whom the Serbs in Croatia have peacefully lived for the past 45 years, could not be excused, neither morally nor politically. After the artificially created euphoria is over, and once peace is established, all reasonable and objective Serbs will -- I strongly believe -- realize that their common life with Croats, in a state with a prosperous economic future, is the most acceptable solution for them.